सत्यमेव जयते

Timeline

- March 1: General Yahya Khan calls off the session of National Council to be held on March 3 in a radio address.
- March 7: Sheikh MujiburRahman - leader of Awami League party that had just won a landslide victory in East Pakistan in the Federal Elections - announces to a jubilant crowd at the Dhaka Race Course ground, "The struggle this time is the struggle for our emancipation! The struggle this time is the struggle for independence!".
- March 9: Workers of Chittagong port refuse to unload weapons from the ship 'Swat'.
- March 10: Expatriate Bengali students demonstrate in front of the United Nations Headquarters and calls for UN intervention to put an end to violence on Bengali people.
- March 16: Yahya Khan starts negotiation with Sheikh MujiburRahman.
- March 19: Nearly 50 people die as Pakistan Army opens fire on demonstrators at Jaydevpur.
- March 24: Pakistan Army opens fire on Bengali demonstrators in Syedpur, Rangpur and Chittagong. More than a thousand people are killed.

Events of the War

March

- March 25: Pakistan Army starts Operation Searchlight in Dhaka and rest of the country, attacking political activists, students, and Bengali members of armed forces and police
- March 26: Independence of Bangladesh is declared by Sheikh MujiburRahman shortly before his arrest. This is Bangladesh's official Independence Day.
- March 31: Kushtia resistance begins.

April

- April 2: Jinjira massacre.
- April 6: The Blood Telegram
- April 11: Radio address by Tajuddin Ahmad, the Prime Minister.
- April 10: A provisional Bangladesh government-in-exile is formed.
- April 12: M. A. G. Osmani takes up the command of Bangladesh Armed Forces.
- April 17: A provisional government-in-exile took oath in Boiddonathtola (now called Mujibnagar) in Meherpur District
- April 18: Battle of Daruin, Comilla and Battle of Rangamati-Mahalchari waterway, Chittagong Hill Tracts.

- April 24: Formation of Bangladesh Action Committee at Coventry, UK by non-resident Bangladeshis.
- April 28: Tajuddin pleas for arms aid to neighbors.

May

- May 5: Gopalpur massacre.
- May 15: Indian army starts aiding MuktiBahini.
- May 20:The Chuknagar massacre takes place at Khulna where the Pakistan army kills nearly 10 thousand people
- May 24: Swadhin Bangla Betar Kendra finds home in Kolkata.

July

- July 11–17: Sector Commanders Conference 1971.

August

- August 1: The Concert for Bangladesh in Madison Square Garden, New York by George Harrison and friends.
- August 16: Operation Jackpot, Bangladesh naval commando operation.
- August 20: Flight Lieutenant MatiurRahman (military pilot)'s attempt to defect by hijacking a fighter.
- August 30: Pakistan Army crackdown on Dhaka guerrillas.

September

- September 5: Battle of Goahati, Jessore.
- September 28: Bangladesh Air Force starts functioning.

October

- October 13: Dhaka guerrillas kill Abdul Monem Khan, governor of East Pakistan.

Freeze Date: Dec 2nd

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The East Pakistan Liberation War

The geographic separation of East Pakistan from the rest of Pakistan has led to a lot of conflicts within the nascent nation. Governor-General Mohammed Ali Jinnah declared that Urdu would be the only common language for Pakistanis, causing significant controversy since most West Pakistanis spoke Punjabi and most East Pakistanis spoke Bengali. Urdu was considered to be an integral cultural aspect of Indian Muslims, and so it was considered to be the most appropriate language for Pakistanis. While most Punjabi speaking West Pakistanis remained silent, Bengali-speaking East Pakistanis revolted, resulting in the deaths of many civilians in a government crackdown in February of 1956. This revolt was seen as a sectional uprising against the interests of Pakistan.

These were the people who gave birth to the dream of Pakistan and watched for 23 years that dream being killed by the military rulers of the western wing. They were denied fruits of their labor, they were denied a voice in their own affairs, they stayed poor so that Islamabad could be rich and with that riches create a powerful military machine. This is seen in the fact that, despite their significantly smaller population, over 40 percent of Pakistan's budget was funneled to the West. Then in 1971 the president of Pakistan General Yayha Khan was forced to hear the voice of these people of Bengal expressed first time in history in the form of free elections daunting Sheikh Mujhibur Rahman of the Awami league party in a landslide victory. The Bengali's do not realize the terrible price they are about to pay.

However, instead of accepting these results, the leader of the Pakistani Peoples Party suggested that there were two prime ministers of Pakistan, one for the East wing and one for the West wing, which elicited outrage in the already incensed East Pakistani population.

This was only exacerbated in 1970 when a tropical cyclone made landfall on the coast of East Pakistan, killing between 300,000 and 500,000 people. The government's failure to respond to the crisis further alienated the citizens of East Pakistan, creating an even deeper resentment in the population. This formed a conflict in East Pakistan that widened into the ongoing Bangladesh Liberation War, a war to make East Pakistan a separate nation known as Bangladesh.

Bangladesh was blot with blood in March 1971 the year of the killing began. While leaders of the west pretend to negotiate with Mujhibur Rehman; the Pakistani military machine prepares to crack down by ship and sea, by secret airlifts, troops are brought to Dhaka. The Pakistani Army initiated Operation Searchlight, an operation to curb the nationalist movement within the Bengali population by taking over key cities and snuffing out any political opposition. All East

Pakistani journalists were systematically deported to start off the operation. Violence was concentrated in Dhaka, especially the residential halls of the University of Dhaka, leading to the deaths of many Bengalis. General Tikka Khan probably known as the "butcher" was sworn in as the Military Governor. On the night of 25th, Army crackdown on the people of Bengal. The Army is indiscriminate in its killings, tank guns are used even against the dormitories of Dhaka University, Surviving students and professors are made to dig their own grave before the army ruthlessly shoots them. Religion has no meaning to the army, Bengali mullah's are butchered in their mosques and Christians and Buddhists were shot. Dhaka's largest temple was reduced to a pile of rubbles after machine gunning all the people inside. Terror and violence become the order of the day in East Bengal and the reign of terror continues as Dhaka becomes a necropolis. In days of Tikka Khan's appointment as military governor a series of devastation is brought about, with the city obliterated and the people burnt to death. The Army acts on one condition i.e. "to be a Bengali is to be a traitor to Pakistan". The Pakistan Army spans out the country side castrating and killing and with each new atrocity, the rank of those who are prepared to fight the army grows. They call themselves the "Mukti Bahini" ,the freedom fighters of Bengal. Women and children were raped and killed by Pakistani Soldiers. East Bengal becomes a giant graveyard, while the settlers flee carrying the world tears of torcher and wholesale murder. Air force is sent in with armored jets to trace and terrify the population. By the end of April it seemed that the Pakistani Army has won and in the jaws of incarceration of West Pakistan. While the mukti's are exterminated, the Awami Leaders in the reminiscence of the liberation Zone raise their flag and declare Bangladesh as an independent country.

For those who survived the Pakistan Army's mastication techniques are too young or too old to fight, the only alternative is escape. Millions flee from Yayha Khan's Army and cross the border into India. This was going to be the greatest migration of people the world had ever witnessed. In the hastily improvised refugee camps setup by the Indian Government the Bengali's encountered more death. Cholera is the new enemy, mothers who fled their homes for the sake of their children watch them die in the refugee camps. The Rich nations promise help but only a fraction of it arrives while the dying in the camps go on and the killing in East Bengal Continues. General Farman Ali, The Military Advisor to the Governor of East Pakistan issued a statement "We are very disciplined army and I deny any atrocities by Pakistani Army. Peace and normalcy as far as physical sense is maintained while the hearts of the people are

yet to be won". He blamed India for false propaganda and lies which were blocking the road to peace and balance in East Pakistan, Mukti Bahini though disagreed.

Whatever the Pakistani Army say in Dhaka the ever swelling ranks Mukti Bahini became an effective guerrilla army with students and peasants also joining in for the cause. Early training is done with substitutes such as bamboo poles, the most promising of recruits are then trained in the use of firearms by trained personnel defected by the Pakistani Army. Such camps multiplied all across East Pakistan, Bengali nationalism acquires a new dimension. In armed camps all over Bangladesh Men train for the liberation of their country. But the courage of the Bengali's is of no match for the Pakistani's who were still being armed by USA and China. Henry Kissinger, Nixon's foreign expert comes to India to explain the inexplicable that American Government will not condemn Yayha Khan's brutalities. Kissinger goes from Delhi to Islamabad illustrating the line American Policy was following. In United Nations, Pakistan Accuses India for creating Famine in East Pakistan to fulfill its own political objectives.

On the question of Refugee return to East Pakistan General Yayha Khan Said "My borders are troubled, not by me but my neighbor by field guns and mortars. I would like to know which civilian would like to cross the border in such conditions." President Yayha Khan forgets that civilians are crossing the border but not in the search for amnesty, they brave the crossfire in order to escape from East Pakistan and the brutalities of the Army.

In the west the Pakistani People are not aware of General's policy of genocide in Bengal and the demand for a war with India grows daily.

President Yayha Khan : "I'm not looking for a war.. I'm trying to avoid it by showing patience but we are very close to the limit of our patience. I make it very clear war is being forced on us by some actions in East Pakistan. An attack on East Pakistan is an attack on Pakistan as a whole."

But it is Yayha Khan who unleashed the war in Bangladesh an unequal war in which soldiers were fitted against children and it is the mothers of East Pakistan who wear the face of patience and despair as they watch their children, those who have survived the jaundice and cholera die in the vague of protein malnutrition. The Foreign press, International statesman, writers, musicians, and ordinary people campaign the cause of Bangladesh but their government's remained indifferent.

India's stance on the conflict

Millions have fled into India seeking refuge. The states of West Bengal, Assam, Tripura, and Meghalaya have established refugee camps along the border. However, this has created an incredible strain on the already overburdened Indian economy. The Indian government has failed to obtain an international response of aid in the conflict.

While the world's press discuss the guerilla's, in India the refugee explosion continues. Indira Gandhi and her government repeatedly tell a deaf world that refugees are not pawns in a political game. For India there is so forgetting that the problem concerns the life of millions of people, those who've fled and those who were still being massacred in East Pakistan. The Refugee concentration in India had reached the 8 million mark. It was India's hard pressed economy that was paying 1 million a day for food and shelter and it is India's poor who resent the injustice of so much money being spent on foreigners. In a desperate attempt to disperse the refugees, thousands of them are taken to inland camps but every group of refugees evacuated there is a group of other needy refugees.

Furthermore, Pakistan's attitude towards India and East Pakistan has become increasingly belligerent and jingoistic. Government propaganda stickers commonly say, "Crush India." The public sentiment in Pakistan is wary of the continued Indian involvement in the conflict, and rumors of attack by Pakistan have struck fear the hearts of many Indians. At this point, war seems inevitable!

International Involvement

USA and China Connection

While the current Indo-Pakistani conflict is brewing in the Indian subcontinent, there are several other ongoing issues in the world outside of it that are important to consider alongside our current issues. The U.S. has been involved in a "Cold War" with the Soviet Union since 1947. A state of continual political tension exists between the two nations and has only been strengthened by the staunch differences in their political philosophies. The conflict between the two goes through phases of tension and calm. Currently, they are in a period of high conflict as tensions have been escalated due to the Brezhnev Doctrine and Sino-Soviet split.

The U.S. is focused on containing the conflict and the spread of communism. In his February 9th State of the World address President Richard Nixon stated that the "United States did not support or condone this military action" in regard to the military actions of West Pakistan.

However, there has been no U.S. reaction to the atrocities in East Pakistan or the stream of refugees into India indicating that the U.S. has given tacit approval of a sort to the West Pakistanis. Criticism of West Pakistan's actions in East Pakistan by the U.S. could weaken Pakistani support of U.S. interests.

The American reaction to the events in West Pakistan have started to be interpreted as not just in favor of West Pakistan's actions but also as an anti-India political stance. India's ties with the Soviet Union have led the U.S. to be wary of any political or military action on the part of India. In addition, India has stated their stance of "non-alignment," which has been interpreted as not supporting American interests. The U.S. seems as if it will side with Pakistan. The two biggest reasons are that Pakistan belongs to CENTO and SEATO, and the U.S. believes India is a pro- Soviet nation despite its stance of non-alignment. Therefore, any victory of India will be considered as the expansion of Soviet influence.

India sought and failed to get American support and sympathy for the Bengalis who were being tortured in East Pakistan or acknowledgment of the refugees flooding India.. On August 9th,

Indira Gandhi finally took a hard move and signed a treaty of peace, friendship and cooperation with the Soviet Union.

This has only served to exacerbate American feelings of distrust and increase tension between the U.S. and India. The U.S. has begun to negatively view Indian intervention in East Pakistan, believing that a war between West Pakistan and India may lead to Indian domination of the subcontinent.

This could result in a stronger Soviet Union foothold in the area, which is exactly the opposite of American foreign policy goals. In addition, the creation of an independent East Pakistan could lead to the collapse of West Pakistan as well, leaving room for the Soviet Union to take control of the South Asian region. The unspoken alliance between India and the Soviet Union and the U.S. and Pakistan will only serve to aggravate the current situation in East Pakistan.

During the second week of July, 1971, Kissinger arrived in Beijing, where he heard the words by then Chinese Prime Minister Zhou Enlai: "In our opinion, if India continues on its present course in disregard of world opinion, it will continue to go on recklessly. We, however, support the stand of Pakistan. If they [the Indians] are bent on provoking such a situation, then we cannot sit idly by.' On this, Kissinger responded that China should know that the US also backs Pakistan on this issue.

Soviet Union Role

As Indira Gandhi had failed to gain American support and sympathy for the Bengalis who were being tortured in East Pakistan, she finally took a hard move and on August 9, signed a treaty of peace, friendship and cooperation with Soviet Union.

The State Department historian says, 'in the perspective of Washington, the crisis ratcheted up a dangerous notch, India and the Soviet Union have signed a treaty of peace, friendship and cooperation.' It was a shock to America as this was what they feared, expansion of Soviet influence in South Asia. They feared that involvement of Soviet Union could sabotage their plan.

Soviet Union had also threatened China that, if they ever opened a front against India on its border, they will receive a tough response from North.